

CASES OF MORPHOSYNTACTIC AFFINITY IN NORTH-EASTERN SIBERIA: BORROWING, SUBSTRATA, SOCIAL SETTINGS' INFLUENCE... OR CHANCE?

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Our study is devoted to patterns of morphosyntax which exhibit areal-like distribution in the languages of Siberia, a zone of low language density with recently discovered peculiar contact patterns (see e.g. Anderson 2006; Packendorf 2020; Matic' et al. 2024). The distribution of 5 morphosyntactic variables we study crosses established genealogical boundaries such as 'Transurasian/Altaic' (see Robbeets, Savelyev 2020) or Uralic-Yukaghir (see Nikolaeva 1988). This makes the contact-induced convergence a possible explanatory scenario for their presence. However, we discuss other possible causes which may have shaped the apparent affinity between the selected linguistic systems of the languages of Siberia¹.

We use a sample of 69 languages (see Figure 1), covering all 9 language families which at least partially enter Siberia and an additional 120-language variety sample covering the world (see Figure 2) to examine (using the methodology provided by Ranacher et al. (2021)) the significance of geography and genealogy for the distribution of the 5 linguistic variables we study (locative case marking Goal (1), prolative case, nominal TAM, verbal attenuative and affixal verbs (2)²). Firstly, we show that the distribution of each variable is unlikely to be attributed to chance resemblance, genealogical inheritance and/or general functional preference (see e.g. Bickel (2015) for a similar approach).

Secondly, we discuss possible development pathways of the discovered 'putatively areal' patterns in question.

The 'areal-like' distribution of several linguistic variables can be attributed to pattern-borrowing (see Gardani 2020) influenced by historically traceable contact evidence of patterns of small-scaled multilingualism similar to attested relatively modern-day ones (e.g. Pupynina, Aralova (2021) for Kolyma region). Namely, the distribution of a Goal-marking function of the locative case and an affinity of Nominal Tense systems of Tungusic and Samoyedic languages can be connected with the spread of reindeer-herding Northern Tungusic people (see Robbeets, Oskolskaya 2022) and contacts between (proto)Tungusic and Samoyedic (see Anikin, Helimsky 2007) respectively.

The prevalence of other categories in Siberia, however, can hardly be attributed to tempting 'pattern-borrowing' or 'Sprachbund' analyses. The presence and internal reconstruction of affixal verbs in Eskimo, Chukotian, Tungusic as well as in some Samoyedic languages cannot be well-aligned with plausible historical timing of contact events and points towards the explanations based on the heritage of a hypothetical Eskimo-like substrate (see Gusev 2021) and a contact-induced retention causes. The wide

¹ We define this area roughly in the following way: between Lena river in the West and Bering Strait in the East geographically, or between Even/Evenki people in the West and Yupik people in the East linguistically as well as Amur river, Sayan and Altay mountains in the South.

² Lexically-heavy bound denominal verbalizers (a subtype of Mithun's (1997) 'lexical affixes').

distribution of attenuative in Siberia is probably due to two different processes: the aforementioned substrate effects in the North-Easternmost area as well as genealogically-based retention-due-to-contact processes in the Westernmost area. Finally, for affixal verbs, attenuative and dedicated prolative, scenarios of independent development due to specific kind of multilingualism (see Epps 2009: 587-590) and/or complexification-due-to-isolation (see e.g. Trudgill 2011: 30-42) cannot be excluded.

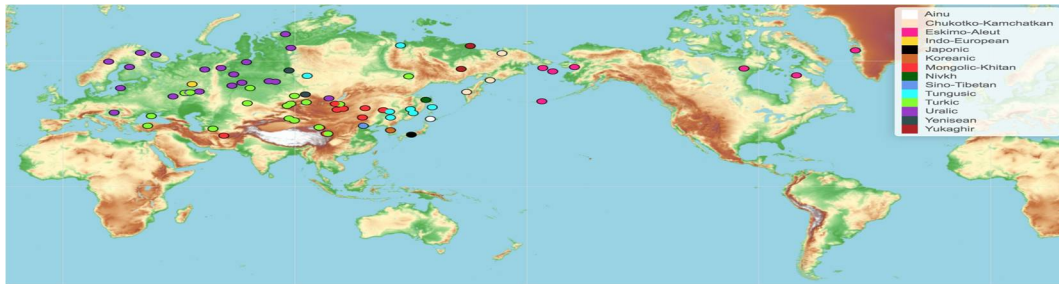


Figure 1. Language sample of Siberia and neighboring areas

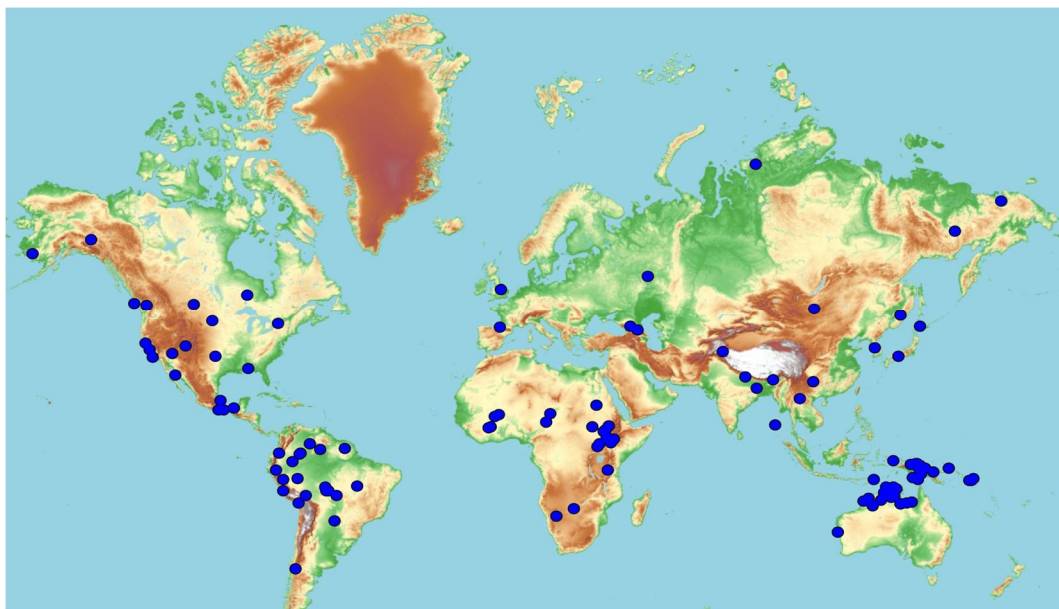


Figure 2. 120-language worldwide variety sample

(2) Locative marking Goal

sal'il ɲodayane luku-n-sisayuu-ya tubegej-l'el-i
mouse top.cntr earth-gen-crack-loc rush.in-nvis-intr.3sg
'But the mouse whisked into a hole'. Northern Yukaghir (Schmalz 2013: 87-88, 90)

(3) Affixal verbs

mət-saj-o-mək=ʔəm I neme
1pl.s/a-tea-eat-1pl.s/o+emph andR again
mət-pʔu-γərki-mək
1pl.s/a-polar.carrot-drag.out-1pl.s/o

'We drank some tea and collected roots again' (personal fieldwork). Chukchi, Amguema variety

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